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Memory and Active Recall: Remember More With Less Rereading

How memory actually works, and how to study in line with it

STUDY SKILLS

Study Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Memory is not a recording device. This pack explains encoding, consolidation and retrieval, then converts that into concrete practice: retrieval questions, spaced schedules, flashcards done correctly and techniques for formulas and vocabulary.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain encoding, consolidation and retrieval in simple terms.
- Design retrieval questions instead of highlighting notes.
- Build and use a spaced-repetition schedule for a semester.
- Use mnemonics and elaboration without relying on them alone.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

How memory works

Information must be encoded, consolidated and retrievable. Each stage can fail.

- Encoding depends on attention and meaningful processing.
- Consolidation happens over time, especially with sleep.
- Retrieval strengthens memory more than rereading.
- Cues help retrieval; learning with varied contexts creates more cues.
- Forgetting is normal and can be countered with spaced review.
- Stress and sleep deprivation impair all three stages.

Retrieval in practice

Turn every page of notes into questions.

- Write questions on the left of the page and answers on the right.
- Close the notes and answer from memory before checking.
- Mark each attempt: confident, shaky or failed.
- Review failed items the next day, shaky items in three days.
- Mix old and new questions in one session.
- Use past questions as retrieval practice, not just as prediction.

> **The flashcard rules**
> One fact per card, a question on the front and a short answer on the back. If a card takes more than ten seconds to understand, split it.

Spacing, sleep and mnemonics

Timing matters as much as technique.

- Review after one day, three days, one week, two weeks and one month.
- Short frequent sessions beat one long session.
- Sleep after study supports consolidation; all-nighters trade memory for anxiety.
- Mnemonics help with lists but do not replace understanding.
- Elaboration - asking why and how - creates stronger, more flexible memories.
- Explain a topic aloud; gaps become obvious immediately.

How memory actually works

Memory is not a store that fills up; it is a set of processes. Information enters working memory, which is small and brief, and moves to long-term memory only through encoding. Retrieval is the act of bringing it back, and retrieval strength is what examinations measure.

Forgetting is not a malfunction. Without forgetting, you would be unable to distinguish what matters now. The forgetting curve is steep in the first day and flattens afterwards, which is why a review within twenty-four hours is disproportionately valuable.

Two principles follow. Spacing: distribute study across days so each session begins with partial forgetting that must be overcome. Retrieval: test yourself rather than review, because the effort of recall is what strengthens the memory.

Techniques that work and techniques that feel like work